



Continuity as an Organizing Variable: Toward Measurable Signatures of Interior Dynamics



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Consciousness, persistence, and organized complexity converge on a shared problem: continuity through time. Continuity as an Organizing Variable treats continuity of internally sustained propagation as a measurable organizational condition contributing directly to persistence and interior dynamics, and it sets out specific cross-domain predictions and measurable proxies for neural, biological, and artificial systems.

Measuring continuity

What role does continuity itself play, as an organizing variable, in persistence and interior dynamics?

How it works

1. **A shared problem.** Biological systems preserve recognizable identity through material turnover. Cognitive systems maintain coherent subjective flow through fluctuating neural activity. Artificial systems display increasingly sophisticated behavior and raise questions about the relationship between computational performance and organized interior structure. All three converge on continuity through time.
2. **Continuity as its own variable.** Continuity itself acts as an organizing variable, alongside complexity, information integration, representation, and local mechanisms of cognition.
3. **Continuity of internally sustained propagation as a measurable condition.** The paper treats it as a measurable organizational condition contributing directly to persistence and interior dynamics.
4. **The coherence-threshold relation.** Organizational behavior is described through $R = \lambda_{\text{self}} / \lambda_{\text{env}} \geq R_{\star}$, where λ_{self} represents internally sustaining dynamics and λ_{env} represents disruptive environmental influence.
5. **Inheritance grows with dominance.** The relation points to future states increasingly inheriting structure from previous states as internally sustained propagation becomes increasingly dominant.
6. **Shared conditions.** Persistence, self reference, and organized interiority can emerge from shared dynamical conditions involving inherited structure across time.

Terms to know

- **Continuity of internally sustained propagation.** The degree to which a system carries its own activity forward through time from within. In plain terms: how well the system carries its own activity forward.
- **λ_{self} .** Internally sustaining dynamics.
- **λ_{env} .** Disruptive environmental influence.
- **$R_{\star}$.** The coherence threshold for a declared system, scale, and interval.

What experiments can check

1. Continuity of retained propagation is predicted to correspond more strongly with organized interior behavior than complexity alone does.
2. Systems approaching threshold conditions are expected to exhibit increasing instability before transitions in organization.
3. Recognition events are expected to emerge from preceding stabilization processes.

Five things to measure

Candidate proxies across neural, biological, and artificial systems:

- **recurrence strength:** how strongly activity feeds back into itself;
- **autocorrelation persistence:** how long a signal stays correlated with its own earlier values;
- **recurrent connectivity:** connections that loop back within the system;
- **context retention:** how long earlier context keeps influencing current behavior;
- **perturbation dynamics:** how the system responds to and recovers from a disturbance.

The bigger picture

This is the second step in measurable terms. Continuity of internally sustained propagation is the quantity predicted to track organized interior behavior: how strongly a system’s own inherited structure shapes its next states.

Full paper on PhilArchive: [Continuity as an Organizing Variable: Toward Measurable Signatures of Interior Dynamics](#)

Before this: [The Ostiary Principle](#).

Next: [Interiority as Lived Continuity](#), on the same continuity as it is lived.

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